

more interested in his subject's struggles within, Gandhi's experiment with his sexuality becomes part of the larger struggle against colonial power. We know: the ageing celibate enjoyed the company of young women. He had written, "Sushila (Nayar) has been present in the bathroom while I have bathed in the nude and in her absence Ba (Kasturba) or Prabhavati or Lilavati have attended on me." He was aware that his experiment was "a violation of the established norms of brahmacharya". He wrote to Vallabhbhai Patel in 1939, "As from yesterday I have stopped sleeping close to them. That is, the girls sleep far enough to be out of reach of my arms." He was the spiritualist for whom his own sexuality—or his struggle with it—was inseparable from his quest for truth: "Those who would make diligent search after Truth—God—must go through these vows: the vow of truth—speaking and thinking of truth—the vow of brahmacharya, of non-violence, poverty and non-possession. If you do not take these five vows you may not embark on the experiment."

Gandhi was a man of many vows, beginning with his doctrinaire vegetarianism in London during his student days. In South Africa, as a civil rights leader of the dispossessed, his first zone of resistance, he perfected the

EXCERPT

Gandhi in his sixties and seventies, with his daily naked massages, joint bathing and young women bedfellows, was getting a good deal more intimate female contact than any but sex industry moguls and rich sybarites do. The honest Sushila, whose concept of truth corresponded more closely to an accepted norm than did Gandhi's, made the point that his sleeping with women came first, while the notion that it was some kind of spiritual experiment emerged after his behaviour had been challenged. Sushila died only in 2001, unmarried; in her sixties she transferred her spiritual affections to another guru, Sathya Sai Baba.

art of persuasion. As the First Satyagrahi in India's freedom movement, he won his argument with the British empire. All the while he continued to challenge his own passions, and all those proverbial demons within. In the end, his life was a permanent war waged within his own moral imperium, where he had no allies. He needed none, for such was his faith in himself. Still, Gandhism, like any ism in a world let down by doctrines, has only marginal relevance. The man is more complex—and enduring—than the ism he spawned. That is why, even as we turn the last page of Adams' study of the phenom, we would like to believe that Gandhi's theology of liberation was not about suppressed libido alone. ■

Empress of Excess

This story of a musical diva is a heady mix of drama, romance and tragedy

By S. Kalidas



MY NAME IS
GAUHAAR JAAN:
THE LIFE AND TIMES
OF A MUSICIAN
by VIKRAM SAMPATH
Rupa
Price: Rs 595
Pages: 318

Gauhar Jaan (1873-1930) was not the greatest of singers of Hindustani music, but she was definitely the most legendary of divas in the high noon of colonial India. Trained in music and dance by the best of masters Gauhar ruled the native *nautch* scene for most of her eventful life like an empress. The toast of every musical event that she deigned to grace from Kolkata to Mysore, Gauhar Jaan even performed for King Emperor George V at the Delhi Durbar of 1911. Educated in Urdu and English she sang in several languages from Persian to Tamil and had honed her arts of seduction (of men) and subversion (of patriarchy) with great finesse. Thanks to her many rich and powerful patrons, in her youth Gauhar was bold, witty, proud and fabulously rich. She was among the very first Indian musicians to record for the newly arrived gramophone record industry in 1902. Her glamorous persona and licentious infamy led to much gossip, myth-making and quite a few court cases. Yet, as it often happens with artists, she was also a victim: of her own excesses and of the evangelist moral hysteria that was sweeping the country at that time. She died addicted to alcohol, almost penniless and very alone in a public hospital in Mysore where she was buried in a now lost unmarked grave.

With a heady mix of drama, romance and tragedy hers is a story that makes for an epic telling. In the latter half of the 20th century, many filmmakers from Guru Dutt and Satyajit Ray to Kamaal Amrohi and Muzaffar Ali drew on Gauhar Jaan's legend while making period films or depicting the *tawaif* character. Vikram Sampath's telling of her life is as much an account of this wide-eyed young South Indian engineer's journey of discovery into a bygone world of music and passion as it is a remarkable recounting of her life based on letters, court records and contemporary narratives especially from vernacular sources. However, the problem lies not with the content but with the form of his opus. Sampath relies on the cloying sentimental style of the 19th century Bengali historical novel; conjuring up descriptions, details and even conversations in gushing prose replete with an underpinning of simplistic moralising. What makes the book significant though are the appendices—a definite contribution to musical documentation—while the preceding docu-drama is fit to inspire the likes of Sanjay Leela Bhansali. ■